

counterparts. The timing for power volleys differs greatly from that of drop volleys. Power volleys are struck with your hitting arm fully extended and far in front of your body. Conversely, drop volleys are contacted with your hitting arm bent — with a much looser grip (softer hands) and a more bevelled racket face — as the ball comes beside your body. The location of the contact point also varies with its height. High contact points are farther away from the torso than low contact points are.

Adjust the length of the backswing based on how much time you have: Andre Agassi's impeccable timing was honed between the ages of three and 13 by hitting an estimated million balls a year that were fired at him at up to 110 miles per hour by the ball machines that his father used in their Las Vegas backyard. "All you really need to succeed at tennis is fast eye-hand coordination," Emmanuel 'Mike' Agassi said in the 1993 biography, *AGASSI*. Indeed, Andre's short groundstroke backswing and extremely short serve return backswing evolved as a survival mechanism.

As a result, Agassi rarely contacted the ball early or late. The eight-time Major champion once averred that the correct contact point was the most important aspect of winning tennis. In today's speedier game, the shorter the backswing, the better, provided you generate power primarily with the legs, hips, torso, and shoulders. Outstanding younger players execute forehands without the head of the racket ever passing behind the plane of the front of their bodies. And this is almost the case for backhands.

Study the spin of the ball and determine how the topspin, underspin, or sidespin of your opponent's shot affects your timing: Extreme spins can bedevil even the most talented and experienced players. For example, every opponent, except perhaps Novak Djokovic, had trouble timing Nadal's ferocious, topspin lefty crosscourt forehands. These diabolical shots bounced fast, high,



and away from opponents. Andy Roddick likened their relentless lethality to 'Chinese water torture'. Late in his career, Federer switched to a larger (97-sq.-in.) racket head with a bigger 'sweet spot' to hit the ball more solidly and reduce off-centre mishits.

While Federer couldn't counteract Nadal's topspin forehand on clay, teenager Steffi Graf overcame a different 'spin' challenge against another sinistral superstar, Martina Navratilova (**facing page**), on grass. Navratilova's slice serve had stymied Graf, pulling her one-handed backhand wide in the ad court and setting up the American's incomparable volley. Graf, an intense perfectionist, figured out the low, swerving trajectory of Navratilova's serve in the 1988 Wimbledon final, broke it eight times, and dethroned her 5-7, 6-2, 6-1. Study the flight of the ball and experiment with different court positions and spins of your own so you can effectively counter extreme spins. This technical

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and timing challenge requires countless hours of practice until the required adjustments become habitual.

Racket head speed can rescue you: To handle oncoming balls that arrive faster than you've anticipated or that you initially misjudge, accelerate your racket head speed while keeping your swing as smooth and coordinated as possible. In emergencies, use your wrist on your forehand to 'flick' the shot like a wristy squash shot.

However, you can significantly alleviate this problem in the first place by early, efficient preparation. Knowledgeable tennis coaches and teaching professionals inculcate the 'Hit-Turn'. With this method, students turn immediately after their opponent contacts the ball and then